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COURT ORDERS OAKLAND TO HIRE BLACK FIREMEN



The Oakland Fire Department is a prime example of the city of Oakland's racist hiring policies. Through the efforts of the Oakland Black Firefighters Association immediate action will be taken to correct this situation. Alameda County Superior Court has ordered the immediate hiring of Black and minority personnel.

(Oakland, Calif.) - Alameda County Superior Judge Robert K. Barber ordered the city of Oakland to hire new fire department personnel at a ratio of two from racial minorities to every White, over the next five years. At the same time the city must promote at least one minority person for every five Whites promoted in the fire department.

The following day, August 29, Deputy City Manager Gerald E. Newfarmer said the fire department "should have little trouble meeting the new standards," and that the department probably will ask the city to promptly start hiring firemen to fill the 38 vacancies which now exist.

The ruling by Judge Barber came in a lawsuit by the Oakland Black Firefighters Association and six minority individuals. The court found there had been discrimination in hiring and promotional practices, in standards and tests for hiring of minorities.

Judge Barber issued a writ commanding the creation of a civil service list for fire fighters set up "only by validated requirements and tests that comply with the Fair Employment Practices Commission guidelines on employee selection procedures."

The city is to promote only by requirements and procedures, Judge Barber said, and these must comply with his ruling — and with validated tests. The judge retains jurisdiction to award damages to other members of the class of minorities, according to proof, after review of the effects of the provisions of the order relating to preferential hiring.

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